

Listening Response Framework

What to Say About What You Hear

MUS/AAS 262 — Jazz History: Many Sounds, Many Voices

The Paragraph Structure

Your listening response is essentially: **What do I hear?** → **What does it mean?**

Write 5–6 sentences hitting these categories in order:

1. **Instrumentation & Ensemble** — What instruments? How many players?
2. **Tempo & Rhythm** — How fast? What's the rhythmic feel?
3. **Timbre & Sound Quality** — What does it *sound like*? (see below)
4. **Melody & Improvisation** — Is the melody stated or improvised? How?
5. **Form & Texture** — What's the structure? Dense or sparse?
6. **Connection** — What era/concept from class does this connect to?

Template sentence

"This piece features _____ [instruments], performing at a _____ [tempo] with a _____ [rhythmic feel]. The soloist's timbre is _____, with _____ [vibrato/articulation]. The form is _____, and a notable feature is _____, which connects to _____ [course concept]."

The Six Categories: What to Listen For & What to Say

1. Instrumentation & Ensemble

What you're identifying: Which instruments are playing and how the group is organized.

If you hear...	You can say...
One instrument alone	“solo piano,” “unaccompanied trumpet”
A few instruments (3–6)	“small combo/ensemble,” “quartet,” “quintet”
Many instruments, sections trading off	“big band,” “full orchestra,” “horn sections”
Trumpet/cornet, clarinet, trombone	“New Orleans front line” (= Early Jazz)
Saxophone sections	“reed section” (= Swing era or later)
Rhythm section only	“piano trio,” “rhythm section” (piano, bass, drums)
Voice as lead	“vocal performance with [accompaniment]”

Also note: Who is the soloist? Is it one person or does the solo pass between players?

2. Tempo & Rhythm

What you’re identifying: How fast it is and how the beat feels.

What to describe	Words you can use
Speed	slow / ballad tempo, moderate / medium tempo, up-tempo, very fast / breakneck
Swing feel	“swinging” (long-short pattern), “straight” (even eighth notes), “stiff” (ragtime-like)
Beat emphasis	“emphasizes beats 2 and 4” (jazz standard), “four-on-the-floor” (every beat even)
Rhythmic energy	“driving,” “relaxed / laid-back,” “pushing forward,” “behind the beat”
Syncopation	“syncopated” (accents on unexpected beats), “rhythmically complex”
Groove	“danceable,” “bouncy,” “relentless,” “floating”

Examples

“The tempo is breakneck, with the rhythm section pushing forward relentlessly.”
 “A relaxed, medium-tempo swing feel with the drummer emphasizing beats 2 and 4 on the hi-hat.”
 “The rhythm feels stiff and march-like, characteristic of early ragtime influence.”

3. Timbre (What Does It *Sound* Like?)

Timbre (pronounced “TAM-ber”) = the **color or quality** of a sound. It’s *why* a trumpet sounds different from a saxophone even when they play the same note at the same volume. Think of it as the “texture” of the sound itself.

Simple way to think about it: If someone asked “describe this instrument’s voice,” timbre is your answer.

Timbre dimension	Words you can use
Brightness	bright / brilliant / piercing vs. dark / warm / mellow / rich
Weight	heavy / thick / full vs. light / thin / airy
Texture	smooth / clean / pure vs. rough / gritty / raspy / buzzy / growling
Breathiness	breathy / airy vs. focused / clear / sharp
Resonance	resonant / ringing / booming vs. dry / muted / dampened
Mood descriptors	yearning, plaintive, joyful, aggressive, tender, strident, wistful, sober

Timbre examples from your listening

Armstrong's trumpet = bright, strident, piercing
Lester Young's sax = light, airy, cool, smooth
Coleman Hawkins' sax = warm, full, lush, heavy vibrato
Billie Holiday's voice = fragile, dark, horn-like, yearning
Bessie Smith's voice = dark, powerful, heavy vibrato
Muted trumpet = dampened, nasal, buzzy (vs. open trumpet = bright, ringing)

4. Vibrato & Articulation

These are two separate things. Both describe *how* notes are played.

Vibrato

What it is: A slight, rapid wavering of pitch on a sustained note. Think of a singer holding a long note and it “wobbles” — that’s vibrato.

What you hear	What to say
Lots of wobble	“extensive/heavy/wide vibrato”
Subtle wobble	“gentle/controlled/narrow vibrato”
Almost none	“minimal vibrato,” “straight tone”
Only at end of notes	“terminal vibrato” (this is Armstrong’s innovation)
Throughout the note	“continuous vibrato” (Hawkins, Bessie Smith)

Articulation

What it is: How each individual note begins and ends — is it punched, slurred, bitten off?

What you hear	What to say
Notes flow together	“legato” (smooth, connected)
Notes are separated/punchy	“staccato” (short, detached, clipped)
Sharp attack on each note	“crisp/hard articulation,” “tongued”
Soft starts	“soft attack,” “gentle onset”
Notes slide between pitches	“glissando,” “sliding,” “scooping into notes,” “bending”
Notes cut off abruptly	“clipped,” “bitten off”
Mix of smooth and punchy	“varied articulation”

Key distinctions from class

Parker (bebop): clear, crisp articulation even at extreme speed — every note distinguishable

Billie Holiday: extreme legato — words and notes spill into each other

Bessie Smith: bending/sliding into notes (blue notes) — instrumentalists copied this

Lester Young: smooth legato lines, behind the beat, relaxed

Hawkins: smooth but active, arpeggiated runs up and down

5. Melody, Improvisation & Harmony

What to describe	Words you can use
Melody stated clearly	“the melody/head is stated clearly,” “recognizable tune”
Melody abandoned	“the soloist departs from the melody,” “improvises freely over the changes”
Melodic shape	“angular” (big jumps), “stepwise” (notes close together), “lyrical,” “singable”
Improvisation style	“collective improvisation” (everyone at once), “solo improvisation” (one person)
Phrasing	“long flowing lines,” “short punchy phrases,” “call and response,” “conversational”
Harmonic complexity	“simple blues harmony,” “complex chord changes,” “playing the changes”
Register	“high register” (Dizzy), “middle register,” “low register,” “altissimo” (extreme high)

Vertical vs. Horizontal (a key distinction)

Vertical (Hawkins) = playing up and down the notes *within* each chord (arpeggios). You hear the chord changes clearly because the soloist outlines them.

Horizontal (Young) = playing melodic lines that flow *across* chord changes. Sounds more like storytelling; you hear a melody, not individual chords.

6. Form, Texture & Special Features

What to describe	Words you can use
Form/structure	“12-bar blues (A,A,B),” “32-bar AABA,” “multi-strain (ragtime),” “contrafact”
Texture (density)	“dense/thick” (many instruments), “sparse/open” (few instruments, space)
Dynamics	“loud/forte,” “soft/piano,” “builds in intensity,” “dynamic contrast”
Call and response	“call-and-response between [X] and [Y]”
Special features	cadenza, spoken intro, scat singing, muted brass, drum feature, walking bass
Arrangement	“tightly arranged,” “head arrangement,” “polished,” “loose/spontaneous”

Putting It All Together: Example Paragraphs

Example: Louis Armstrong — “West End Blues” (1928)

This piece opens with an **unaccompanied trumpet cadenza** — Armstrong playing alone with no rhythm section, demonstrating virtuosic technique. The tempo settles into a **slow, relaxed 12-bar blues**. Armstrong’s trumpet timbre is **bright and strident**, with **vibrato applied at the end of sustained notes** rather than throughout — a technique he pioneered. His articulation alternates between **smooth legato phrases** and **crisp, punched notes**. The texture shifts between **solo trumpet and the full ensemble** (clarinet, trombone, piano), with the band providing a **sparse** backdrop during solos. This piece exemplifies Armstrong as the “First Great Soloist” (Schuller), transforming jazz from collective ensemble music into a vehicle for individual expression.

Example: Coleman Hawkins — “Body and Soul” (1939)

This is a **tenor saxophone** with rhythm section (piano, bass, drums) performing at a **slow ballad tempo**. Hawkins’s timbre is **warm, full, and lush**, with **extensive vibrato throughout** his sustained notes. He **barely states the original melody**, instead improvising almost entirely over the 32-bar AABA chord changes. His approach is **vertical** — you can hear him running **arpeggios up and down the chord tones**, reaching into the **altissimo register**. The texture is **sparse**, with the rhythm section staying out of the way. This recording demonstrates Hawkins as the “Father of the Jazz Tenor Saxophone” and his chordal/vertical approach that contrasts directly with Lester Young’s horizontal style.

Example: Charlie Parker — “Ko Ko” (1945)

A small **bebop combo** — alto saxophone (Parker), trumpet, piano (Miles Davis), bass, and drums (Max Roach). The tempo is **extremely fast, almost breakneck**. Parker’s timbre is **bright and focused**, and his articulation is remarkably **crisp and clear even at this speed** — every note is distinguishable. The piece opens with a **pre-composed introduction** before Parker launches into an **extended improvised solo** over “I Got Rhythm” chord changes (a contrafact). His melodic lines are **angular**, with large intervallic leaps and **syncopated, unpredictable phrasing**. Max Roach drives the rhythm from the **ride cymbal** rather than the bass drum, characteristic of bebop drumming. This is bebop as “art music, not dance music” — the complexity and speed demand focused listening, not dancing.

Cheat Sheet: Quick Vocabulary by Category

Category	Go-to words
Tempo	slow/ballad, moderate, up-tempo, breakneck/blazing
Rhythm	swinging, straight, stiff, syncopated, driving, laid-back, behind the beat
Timbre	bright vs. dark, warm vs. piercing, breathy vs. focused, smooth vs. gritty, lush, fragile
Vibrato	extensive/heavy, gentle/subtle, minimal/none, terminal (end of note only)
Articulation	legato (smooth) vs. staccato (punchy), crisp, sliding/bending, clipped
Melody	angular vs. stepwise vs. lyrical, stated vs. improvised, long lines vs. short phrases
Improv	collective vs. solo, vertical (chordal) vs. horizontal (melodic), “playing the changes”
Texture	dense vs. sparse, full band vs. stripped down, section playing vs. solo
Dynamics	quiet/soft, loud/powerful, builds in intensity, dynamic contrast
Form	12-bar blues, 32-bar AABA, contrafact, head arrangement, multi-strain